

Canis aureus

Golden jackal



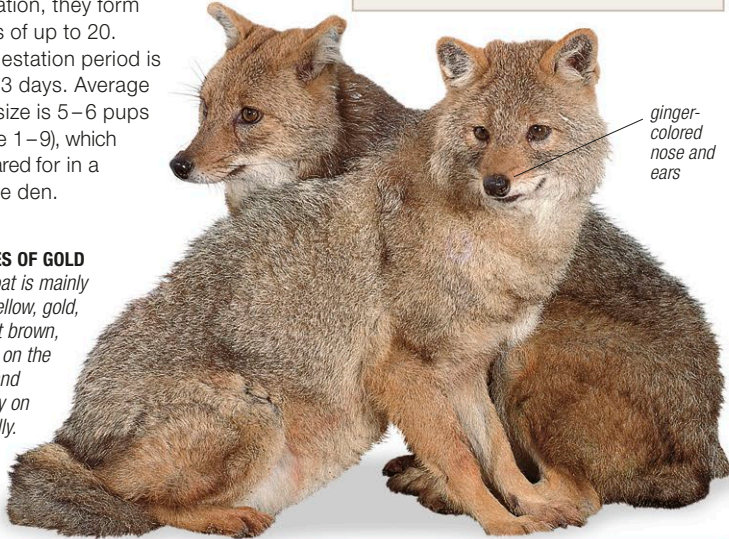
Location S.E. Europe,
W. to S.E. Asia

Length 29–33 in
(74–84 cm)
Tail 8–9½ in
(20–24 cm)
Weight 14–22 lb
(6.5–9.8 kg)
Social unit Pair
Status Least concern



These omnivorous, opportunistic jackals usually live as breeding pairs, but in areas with plentiful food, such as refuse dumps near human habitation, they form packs of up to 20. The gestation period is 60–63 days. Average litter size is 5–6 pups (range 1–9), which are cared for in a secure den.

SHADES OF GOLD
The coat is mainly pale yellow, gold, or light brown, grayer on the back and gingery on the belly.



MEALTIME



Golden jackal pups move on from milk to solid food at about 8–10 weeks. At this age they are too young to hunt, so parents, older siblings, and other young adults regurgitate meals for them on return from a successful outing.

Canis latrans

Coyote



Location North America to
N. Central America

Length 27½–38 in
(70–97 cm)
Tail 12–15 in
(30–38 cm)
Weight 20–35 lb
(9–16 kg)
Social unit Variable
Status Least concern



The coyote, like many canids, is highly adaptable in habitat and opportunistic in diet. Once believed to be always solitary, it may also form a breeding pair or, when larger prey is common, gather as a small hunting pack. Food varies from pronghorns, deer, and mountain sheep to fish, carrion, and refuse. The coyote is a rapid sprinter (40 mph/65 kph) and often runs down jackrabbits. Its well-known nocturnal howl usually announces an individual's territory or location to neighbors. Mating occurs from January to March, gestation takes 63 days, and the litter size is 6–18 (average 6). The pups are born in a secure den.

COLORATION
The grizzled buff coat is yellowish on the outer ears, legs, and feet. Underparts are gray or white. The shoulders, back, and tail may be tinged black.

STALK AND POUNCE



The coyote, like many similar species, uses a characteristic pounce to catch small prey, such as mice, in snow or grass. It moves forward slowly, watching and listening intently. Having located the prey, it leaps almost vertically into the air and brings its front feet down onto the animal, pinning it to the ground before killing it with a bite.



Canis mesomelas

Black-backed jackal



Location E. and southern
Africa

Length 26–35 in
(65–90 cm)
Tail 10–16 in
(26–40 cm)
Weight 13–26 lb
(6–12 kg)
Social unit Pair
Status Least concern



This jackal's range extends from city suburbs to the deserts of southern Africa. The main coloration is ginger to red-brown with a distinctive black saddle over its shoulders and back, and a black, bushy tail. Female and male mate for life and hunt together as adaptable omnivores. Their prey includes livestock such as sheep or young cattle. Their breeding habits resemble those of other jackals.



Canis simensis

Ethiopian wolf



Location E. Africa

Length 2¼–3¼ ft
(0.84–1 m)
Tail 10½–15½ in
(27–39.6 cm)
Weight 24–43 lb
(11–19.5 kg)
Social unit Group
Status Endangered



Formerly known as the Simien jackal, this species may mate with domestic dogs, which has affected their genetic integrity. They are at risk from habitat loss, competition and diseases from domestic dogs, and overgrazing, which has reduced their prey of hares, rodents, and giant mole rats. Groups of up to 13 wolves congregate noisily at morning, noon, and evening; most hunting is around dawn and dusk. Both parents and young adult “helpers” protect and regurgitate food for the cubs.

Canis rufus

Red wolf



Location Reintroduced to
E. USA (North Carolina)

Length 3¼–3½ ft
(1–1.25 m)
Tail 11¼–18 in
(29.5–46 cm)
Weight 44–75 lb
(20–34 kg)
Social unit Group
Status Critically endangered



By the 1970s, red wolves were believed to be extinct in the wild due chiefly to persecution and interbreeding with coyotes. Reintroduced from 1987 in North Carolina, they have established a population of more than 50. They hunt mammals such as rabbits, coypu, and raccoons, and live in packs with

a social organization comparable to that of the gray wolf (see p.174). The coat is tawny-cinnamon mixed with gray and black, and is darkest on the back.

